etch

sketch without stress

Our value

Turn **everyday moments** into **low-pressure art prompts** that help creatives rediscover inspiration and **remember the joy of the creative process**



Elsa
BS Design
MS HCI



Ahyan
BS CS



Jia
BS Design
MS HCI



Kelly
BS HCI
MS AI

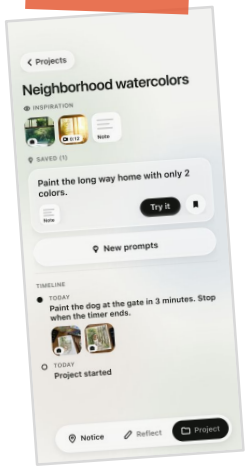
The problem

Pressure to perform and produce can leave creatives burned out and disconnected from the joy of making.

Our solution

A private space to capture everyday inspiration, reflect on what matters, and reconnect those discoveries to creative projects.

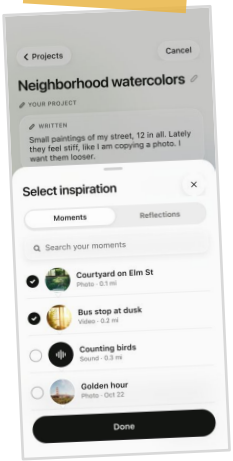
OUR DESIGN VALUES



Process over result



Flexibility



Inspiration

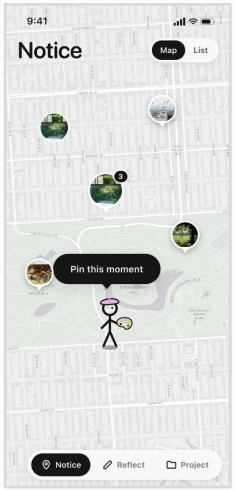


Agency

VALUE TENSIONS

Inspiration → **Process**

before → **now**

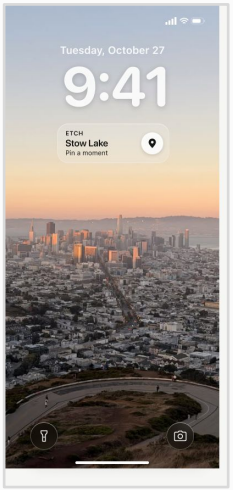


~~Others' art on the map~~

Only what you noticed

Flexibility → **Agency**

before → **now**



~~"Go here" notifications~~

Pin a moment where you are

CORE DESIGN VALUE

Process over result

Why it matters

Pressure to produce polished work can make creativity feel like another obligation. Etch makes noticing, experimenting, and reflecting worthwhile on their own.

How Etch supports it

Capture inspiring moments without making art immediately. Reflect along the way, and optionally log project progress in a discrete timeline.

CORE DESIGN VALUE

Flexibility

Why it matters

Creative processes differ across people, projects, and mediums. Capturing inspiration should fit the way each person thinks and works.

How Etch supports it

Save photos, videos, or audio. Reflect through text or voice, and connect moments to different projects as ideas evolve.

CORE DESIGN VALUE

Inspiration

Why it matters

When creatives feel burned out or lose motivation, a small moment of curiosity can offer a gentle starting point.

How Etch supports it

Prompts build on moments users already found meaningful in their surroundings. They offer a personal invitation to explore, without demanding immediate art-making.

CORE DESIGN VALUE

Agency

Why it matters

Our testing suggests artists value control and ownership. Their inspiration, reflections, and creative direction should feel like their own.

How Etch supports it

Keep maps, reflections, and projects private. Users choose what to capture and connect; optional prompts offer support while leaving creative decisions to them.

VALUE TENSIONS #1

Our goal of **fostering inspiration** led us to let users discover others' artwork on the map. However, this created **tension with valuing the personal creative process**, shifting attention toward finished results and comparison.

We addressed this by making the environment the source of inspiration instead. Now users capture "moments" in their surroundings like a video or audio and reflect on what resonated with them.

VALUE TENSIONS #2

Our goal of **supporting flexibility** led us to offer both manual map pins and notifications that directed users to nearby places where others had made art. However, these nudges created **tension with agency**: users described dismissing notifications and not wanting the app to tell them where to go.

We addressed this by making moments easy to pin from their phone, while letting users decide when and where to capture inspiration (aka removing notifications).

ORIGINAL TASKS

SIMPLE

Discover inspiration

“Imagine you're taking a short break and want to find inspiration outside. Use the app to find a place to create.”

MODERATE

Create and save

“You've arrived at that spot and made a piece of art. Use the app to save it.”

COMPLEX

Revisit and connect

“You've made several pieces with etch. Use them to reflect on or find inspiration for your own craft.”

REVISED TASKS

SIMPLE

Notice inspiration

“Imagine you're going about your day and something catches your attention. Use Etch to capture and save that moment of inspiration.”

MODERATE

Reflect on moments

“You've saved several inspiring moments. Use Etch to reflect on what made them meaningful to you.”

COMPLEX

Connect to projects

“You're starting a new creative project and need inspiration. Use Etch to connect your saved moments to your craft and track your progress.”

Simple: One capture-and-save flow.

Moderate: Select moments and add reflections.

Complex: Connect inspiration to projects through multiple steps.

WHY WE REVISED THE TASKS

User feedback led us to support how artists naturally find and use inspiration.

Personal observation

Users choose which moments to pin on their map, letting personal discoveries guide them rather than app-recommended destinations.

Personal reflection

Explore why a moment matters, without pressure to make art immediately.

Creative projects

Connect saved moments to ongoing work through projects and personalized prompts.

Focus: artists seeking inspiration for new or ongoing projects.

KEY MEASUREMENTS

USABILITY GOAL

Pleasing

High user satisfaction

Our users are burnt out, so using etch should feel like a break

Key Measurement

Satisfaction rating (1-7)

Low-fi Findings

Users wanted less pressure to create and more freedom to explore inspiration.

Progress

Shifted toward noticing and reflecting without requiring immediate artistic output.

KEY MEASUREMENTS

USABILITY GOAL

Flexible

Multiple ways to complete tasks

Needfinding showed creatives need both structure to start and freedom to explore

Key Measurement

Flexibility rating (1-7) and unassisted completion

Low-fi Findings

Users wanted different ways to find inspiration and connect it to their craft.

Progress

Added independent Notice, Reflect, and Projects activities with optional inputs.

CHANGES TO ACHIEVE GOALS

Pleasing

Remove guided exploration and social pressure for more relaxed, self-directed experience

Allow users to save and reflect without creating art for less pressure and greater satisfaction

Flexible

Support photos, videos, audio, and written reflections for more ways to capture inspiration

Add optional prompts connected to personal projects so users can choose how to explore and create

THREE SKETCH REVISIONS

01 User-led discovery

Replace nearby artwork and directions with personal moments pinned where users are.

02 Connect inspiration to a project

Select moments and reflections as sources for an optional project prompt.

03 More ways to capture

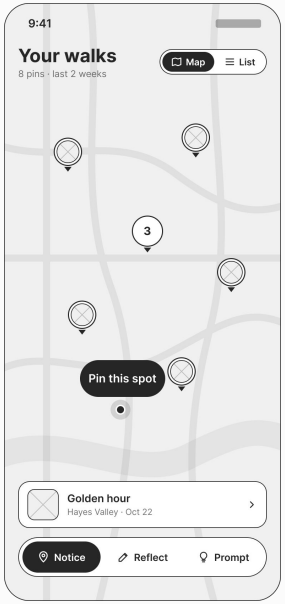
Capture photos, videos, or sound instead of assuming every moment is a finished sketch.

01 USER-LED DISCOVERY

BEFORE



AFTER



1 Before: art at a place

Pins and “Take me somewhere” direct users toward others’ artwork.

2 After: my discoveries

Personal moments replace an art-discovery map.

3 After: pin here

Users capture where they are, without a notification or trip.

WHY CHANGE DISCOVERY?

“I try to make them all go away as much as possible”

Booker (P1), on notifications

“I’d like to envision myself … in this area not just see what someone drew in an area”

James (P4), Task 1

Observed issue

P1 dismissed notifications; P4 wanted to see the place, not just art made there.

Design response

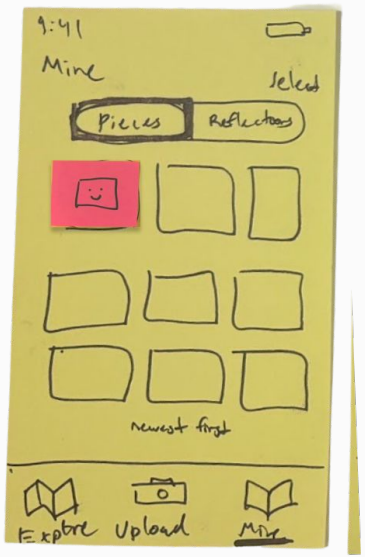
Make the map personal. Pin inspiration where the user is.

Goal: pleasing

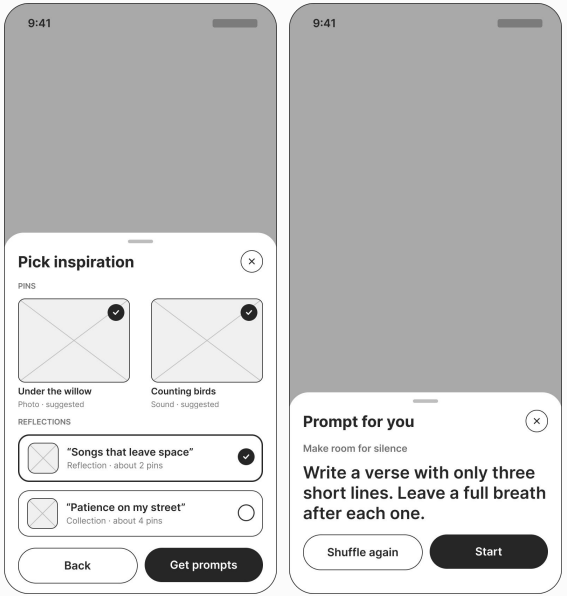
Reduce unwanted direction and effort. Test whether discovery feels like a break.

02 CONNECT TO A PROJECT

BEFORE



AFTER



1 Before: a collection

Pieces and reflections sit together, but the next step into a craft is unclear.

2 After: choose sources

Select personal moments and reflections for a project.

3 After: use the connection

An optional prompt turns selected inspiration into a starting point.

WHY CONNECT TO PROJECTS?

“What am I doing then?”

Booker (P1), Task 3

“Then I’d realize my art probably doesn’t inspire me that much”

James (P4), Task 3

Observed issue

Past work did not reliably connect to a main craft. P1 needed the task reframed.

Design response

Select moments and reflections for a project, then offer an optional prompt.

Goal: flexible

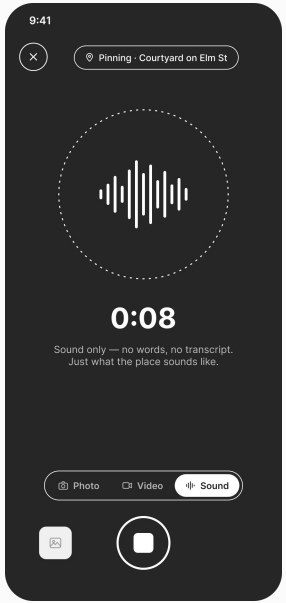
Test whether users can connect inspiration to a real project without facilitator help.

03 MORE WAYS TO CAPTURE

BEFORE



AFTER



1 Before: photo of art

The capture flow assumes a finished sketch to photograph.

2 After: choose a format

Photo, video, or sound can capture a moment in the environment.

3 After: record progress

Reuse these options for project progress; a polished piece is not required.

WHY EXPAND CAPTURE?

“I’m trying to create an audio… I don’t really see the option.”

Cyrus (P3), Task 2

“I appreciate that there’s a transcript and an audio … I can just read it”

Jonas (P2), Task 3

Observed issue

P3 needed help to find audio reflection. P2 valued audio and text choices.

Design response

Expose capture formats together and make reflection easy to find.

Goal: flexible

Test preferred ways to capture and reflect. Video capture extends the concept and still needs validation.

HOW WE WILL CHECK PROGRESS

Pleasing

Low-fi findings: Users disliked unwanted notifications and pressure to create.

Changes made: Removed guided exploration and allowed users to save and reflect without creating art.

Measurement: Target satisfaction rating of 5+ (1–7 scale).

Flexible

Low-fi findings: Users struggled to find reflection options and connect past work to their craft.

Changes made: Added accessible reflection options and personalized project prompts.

Measurement: Target flexibility rating of 5+ (1–7 scale) and unassisted task completion.

REQUIRED ELEMENTS

Colors & roles

Mostly neutral. Red and blue are kept for status.

Ink	Ink 2	Paper	Glass
Text, primary button	Meta text, icons	App background	Cards, sheets, controls

Line	Blue	Red	Yellow
Dividers	You are here, confirm	Recording, delete	Active camera mode

Repeating icons

Thin line icons, all with the same stroke.

Back · Done · Close

Back, Done and Close show up in every task. Done is our submit action. The others are used in the tab bar and buttons.

Type & roles

Screen titles use SF Pro Rounded. Everything else is SF Pro.

Notice
Screen title · Rounded 40

Select pins
Page title · 28

Courtyard on Elm St
Sheet title · 24

Keeping time for everyone
Card title · 16

It felt like the whole street slowed down.
Body · 14

Pin this moment
Button label · 15

Search your pins
Input / placeholder · 15

Reflect · **Cancel**
Top bar · 15

Oct 12 · 4:12 pm
Meta · 13

YOUR REFLECTION
Eyebrow · 11 caps

Buttons

The dark button is the main action. Glass buttons are for everything else.

Save reflection

Pin this moment · Skip

+ Add Reflection · Next → · Next →

Main · Dark pill · Glass · Close · Add · Next · Disabled

Inputs

Light fields with no border.

Search your pins

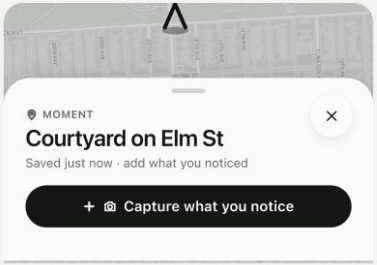
Title Golden hour

WRITTEN
The dog didn't move for twenty minutes. Everyone stepped around it, like it belonged there more than we did.

Search · Title, empty and filled · Written note

Modal · bottom sheet

A sheet slides up over the map, with a close button and the main action at the bottom.



Dropdown

Tapping the button opens a short menu. Delete is last, in red.

Newest first

Newest first
Oldest first
Delete pin

Design System Justification

Rationale

- **Colors:** Black, white and gray work like a blank canvas, so users' own photos and sounds add the color. When an earlier map showed other people's art, attention moved to finished work and comparison. Red only marks recording and deleting, and blue only shows your location.
- **Fonts:** Titles use SF Pro Rounded, which feels softer. Our users are burned out, so Etch should feel like a break. All other text uses SF Pro, the standard iPhone font, so it is familiar and easy to read.
- **Contrast and visibility:** Dark text on light backgrounds keeps everything readable. Buttons and sheets are see-through glass, so the map or photo stays visible. In low-fi testing, P4 wanted to "envision myself … in this area," not only see what others drew there.
- **No set style:** Every artist has their own style. In needfinding, Noah stepped back from work buyers expected so his own voice could evolve, and the conditions for play were different for each crafter. A plain design leaves room for each user's style.

ADDITIONAL ELEMENTS

Navigation

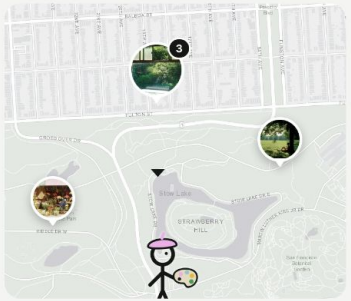
The tab bar switches between the three tasks. Notice can show a map or a list.

Notice · Reflect · Project

Map · List · Map · List

Map pins

Each pin shows its photo. Nearby pins group into one with a count. The painter is you.



Camera

Dark controls, so the camera view stays the brightest part of the screen.

NOTICING · COURTYARD ON ELM ST

Photo · Video · Sound

REC 0:06

Media

Your capture, with retake and remove right below it.



Retake · Remove photo

Back to all 3

Gallery tiles · Media actions · Back link

Notes & reflections

Voice and written notes use the same card. The buttons inside stay small.

VOICE NOTE 0:42

TRANSCRIPT

It felt like the whole street slowed down around the dog, like it was keeping time for everyone.

REFLECTION 0:42 Oct 12

Keeping time for everyone

"It felt like the whole street slowed down around the dog…"

Labels & feedback

Small caps labels name each section. A toast confirms a save.

YOUR REFLECTION

PINNED Photo

Reflection saved · Only you can see this

Lists

Check pins to select them. A link row opens a related reflection.

Courtyard on Elm St
Photo · 0.1 mi

Counting birds
Sound · 0.3 mi

Keeping time for everyone
Voice · 0:42 · Oct 12

Empty states

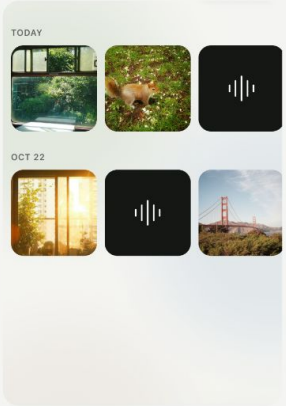
Explains what will show up here and gives one way to start.

No reflections yet

A reflection is a short note about moments you pinned. Write a few lines or just talk for a minute. Only you can see it.

+ Add Reflection

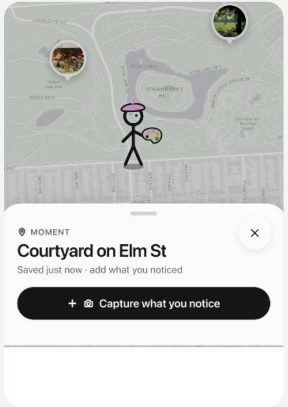
VISUAL DESIGN CHOICES



01

A quiet interface

We kept the app black, white and gray. That way your photos, sounds and the map are the most colorful things on screen.



02

See-through controls

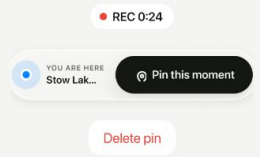
Buttons and sheets are frosted glass, so you can still see the map or photo behind them.



03

One main button per screen

Each screen has one dark button for the next step. Smaller actions like edit or delete sit next to what they change.



04

Color for status only

Red only shows up for recording and deleting. Blue only marks where you are.

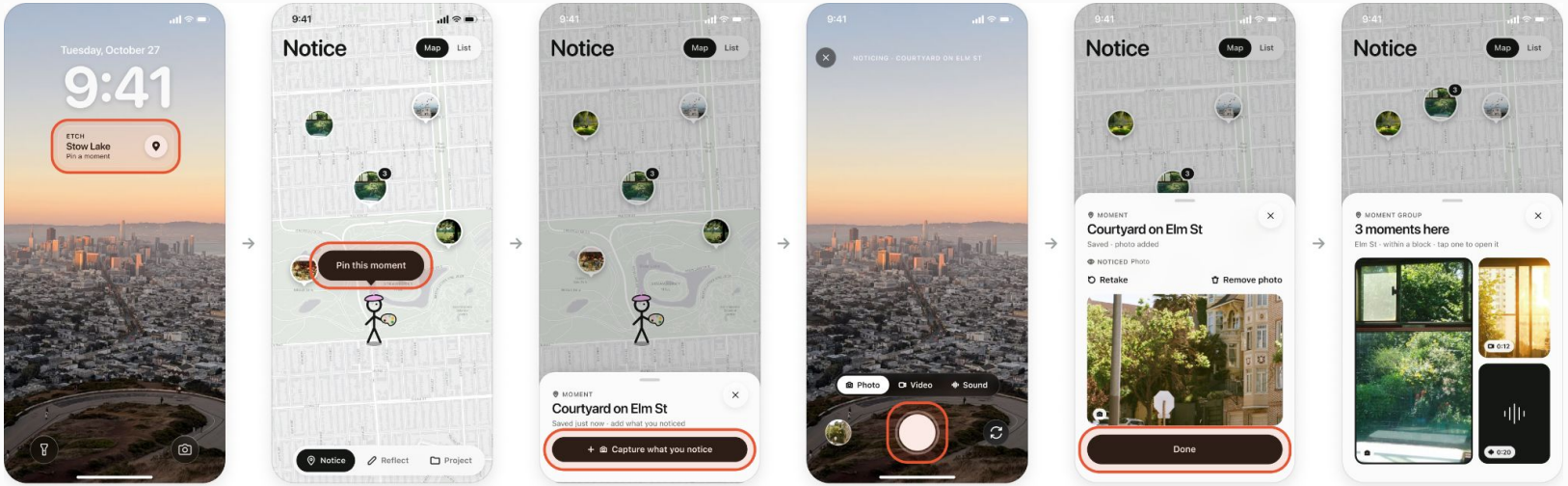


05

Rounded titles

Titles use SF Pro Rounded, which feels softer and closer to the hand-painted case. Body text is SF Pro, the standard iPhone font.

TASK FLOW 1



1 Open from the lock screen

Tap the Etch widget. No unlocking or hunting for the app.

2 Pin this moment

The map shows where you are. One tap drops a pin right there.

3 The pin is saved

The location is saved right away. Adding a capture is optional.

4 Take a photo, video or sound

Pick a mode at the bottom and tap the shutter.

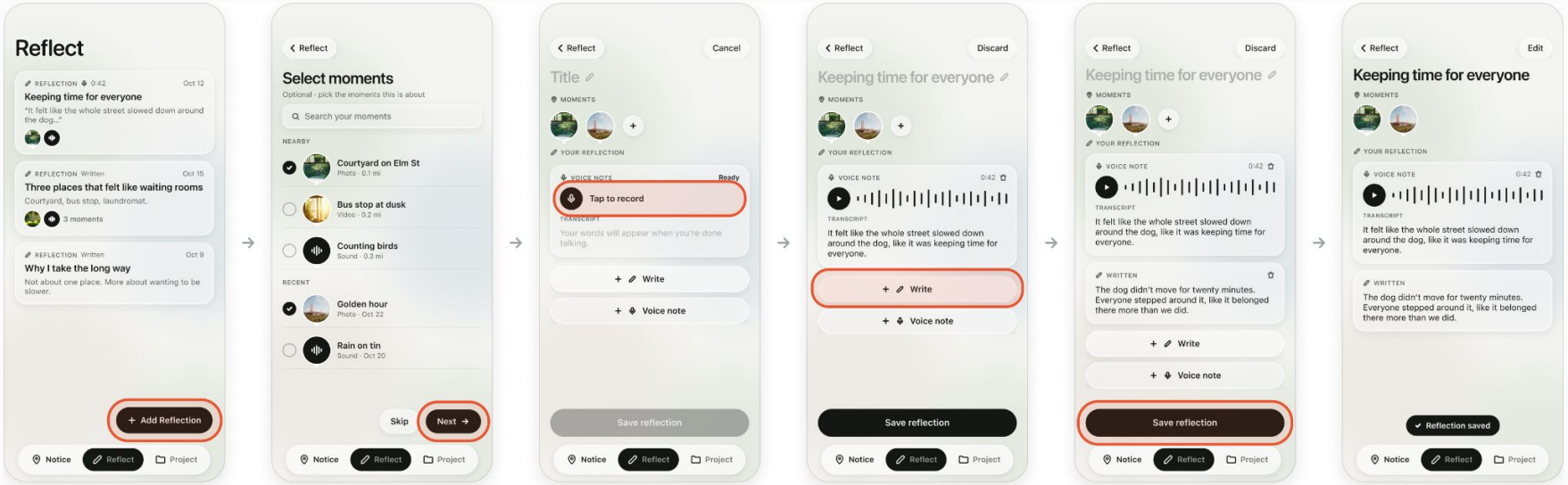
5 Check it and finish

Retake or remove if you need to, then tap Done.

6 Look back later

Moments close together group into one. Tap a group to see them all.

TASK FLOW 2



1 Start a reflection

From the Reflect tab, tap Add Reflection.

2 Pick the moments

Check the moments this is about, or skip this step.

3 Talk it through

Tap record and talk for a minute.

4 Read the transcript

Your words show up as text. You can add a written note too.

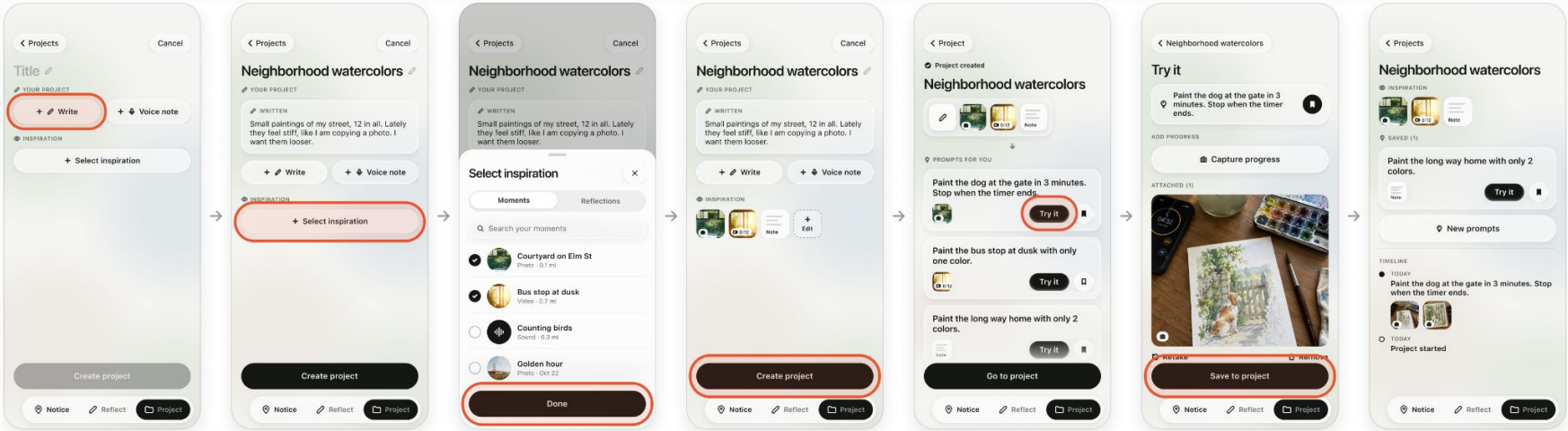
5 Save it

Both notes sit in one draft. Tap Save reflection.

6 Come back anytime

The reflection keeps its notes and the moments it is about.

TASK FLOW 3



1 Start a project

Give it a title, then write or record what you are making.

2 Add inspiration

Tap Select inspiration to pull in moments and reflections.

3 Pick what fits

Check moments on one tab and reflections on the other.

4 Create the project

Your note and picks show together. Tap Create project.

5 Get prompts

Etch suggests small things to try, each linked to what inspired it.

6 Try one

Capture your progress with the camera, then save it.

7 See the timeline

The prompt you tried moves onto the timeline with your photos.

FIGMA (Link at bottom)

We used Figma for creating our med-fi prototype, both for imagining different screens and then connecting them for interactive task flows.

Our priority was testing usability, task flows, and visual design rather than implementing a functional app:

Pros

- Easy to reuse components and make design changes.
- Interactive prototypes without writing code.

Cons

- Limited real-world functionality.
- Interactions rely on predefined screens and transitions.

https://www.figma.com/design/q1CqyCqSM2ClbAZqmbeeVK/A6-Prototype?node-id=0-1&p=f&t=dXI3bme3f0bfRXHn-0

IMPACT & LIMITATIONS

Predefined Interactions

- **Limitation:** Users follow predefined task flows.
- **Impact:** Users cannot freely explore every interaction.

Limited Device Integration

- **Limitation:** Camera, audio, and location features are simulated.
- **Impact:** Does not fully represent real-world use.

Static Content

- **Limitation:** Moments, reflections, and projects use example content.
- **Impact:** Less personalization to users' interests.

Simulated Prompts

- **Limitation:** Creative suggestions are predefined rather than generated.
- **Impact:** Cannot fully evaluate personalized inspiration.

Despite these limitations, users can still evaluate navigation, interface clarity, and task completion within our prototype.

Simulated Features

- Camera and audio recording interactions.
- Saving and retrieving moments or reflections.
- Generating personalized creative prompts.

Hard-Coded Content

- Example photos, recordings, and reflections.
- Sample creative projects and suggestions.
- Predefined task paths and screen transitions.

ALL VALUES IN DESIGN (APPENDIX)

- **Process Over Results:** Encourage exploration without pressure to produce polished work.
- **Flexibility:** Support different ways of capturing, reflecting, and creating.
- **Inspiration:** Help users discover creative ideas from everyday experiences.
- **Agency:** Let users control their creative process and personal content.

ADDITIONAL REFINEMENTS (APPENDIX)

Clear private saving

P1 asked, “Am I saving this for myself or am I submitting this to someone?”

Keep moments private and use “Save” rather than “Submit.”

A direct reflection action

P3 could not find audio reflection. Make it a visible action, not a hidden step after uploading art.

Keep text and voice options

P2 valued transcript and audio. Distinguish personal reflection from environmental sound capture.

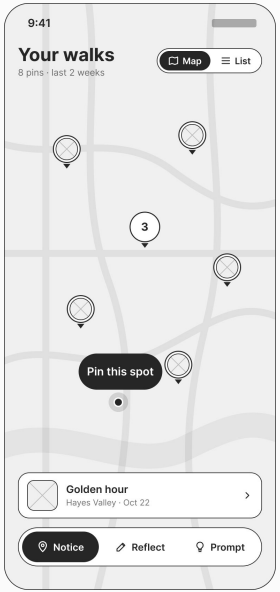
Evidence: P1 Task 2; P3 Task 2; A5 Task 3 reflection feedback. Refinements require validation.

WIREFRAME REFERENCE 1 (APPENDIX)

BEFORE



AFTER

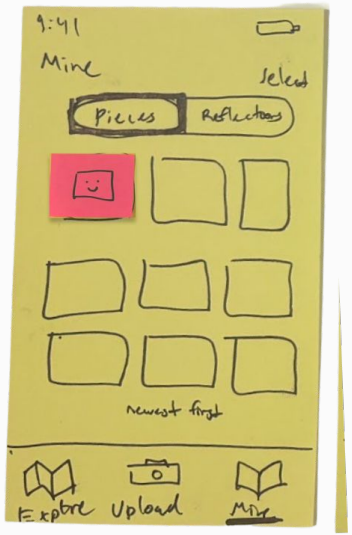


The supplied digital wireframe explores personal pins and a “Pin this spot” action.

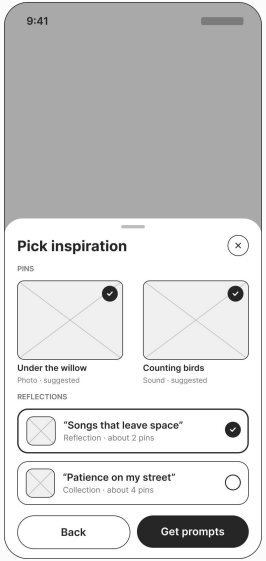
The main section shows a separate schematic revision sketch with annotations.

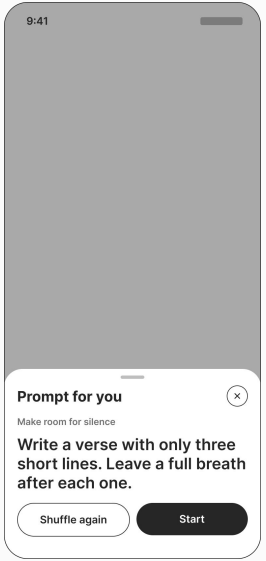
WIREFRAME REFERENCE 2 (APPENDIX)

BEFORE



AFTER





The supplied digital wireframes show selecting saved moments and reflections, then receiving a project prompt.

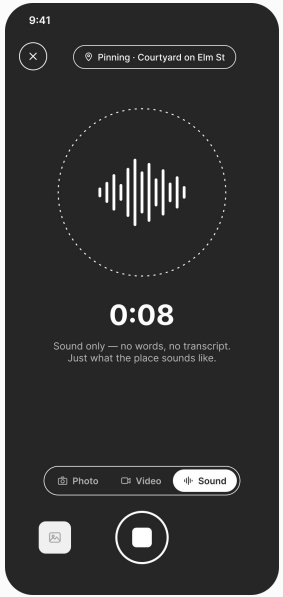
These references are separate from the revised sketches.

WIREFRAME REFERENCE 3 (APPENDIX)

BEFORE



AFTER



The supplied digital wireframe offers Photo, Video, and Sound in one capture flow.

These references are separate from the revised sketches.